

Response Paper to *Liquid Democracy: Potentials, Problems, and Perspectives*, by C.Blum and
C.I.Zuber

Pirate parties seem to hold little power in modern political systems, and are often disregarded as marginal groups with little impact on democracies. However, the Pirate Parties International, present in 43 countries with seats in the European Union parliament and local, regional, and national level decision making institutions, says otherwise. Among its alternative propositions, a system of intra-party decisions attests of its avant-gardism: liquid democracy. In this response paper, I will discuss Christian Blum and Christiana I. Zuber's *Liquid Democracy: Potentials, Problems, and Perspectives*. To do so, I will first go over the theoretical implications of this democratic model, then examine the relevance of its novelty, the problems that come with it, different suggestions to tackle these problems, and finally observe some challenges to its practical implementation.

First of all, liquid democracy is a hybrid model that combines direct democracy participation with a flexible model of representation. By taking advantage of the highlights of the first and making them compatible with the second, four properties emerged from the original idea, introduced by James Miller in 1969. All members of a political community are entitled to infer in each of these properties: they can directly vote on all political issues (direct democracy component), delegate their vote to a representative (flexible delegation), delegate the votes received to another representative (meta-delegation), and terminate the delegation of votes at all times (instant recall). This means, voting is done simultaneously directly and indirectly, and the weight of representatives varies with the support of electors.

Secondly, liquid democracy is designed to overcome the major flaws of traditional models and is a refreshing proposition. One of the most impactful characteristics of representative democracies is its 2-class system: a class of principals authorizes other members to vote on their behalf, while a class of representatives votes on all policies. In the proposed model, representatives are not replaced by issue competent and area specific delegates that can see the votes entrusted to them retracted if citizens are not satisfied, but all members are also entitled to vote directly on all policies. This allows elections to be turned towards actual issues beyond voting for representatives, which better reflects voter interests and improves legislature's performance by always having

informed and competent experts as influential opinions. Interestingly, strategic voting, which can tamper with election results, can be argued to act as a compromise to ensure another democratic component is observed: the urgency of personal preferences. The relative urgency of a preference is a factor of importance not accounted for in agrarian models of democracy; vote trading can allow someone to make concessions on policies they deem less important to make sure their point gets across in the ones they find urgent. Coordinating with multiple people this way is only feasible in liquid democracy and seems to encourage a healthy form of strategic voting.

Nevertheless, liquid democracy is not a perfect model, and various problems arise from it. First and foremost, policy inconsistency seems to be the biggest challenge: as there is no incentive to form alliances across policy areas, a lack of coordination of the overall policy output creates contradictions between measures passed. Besides, the informational demand is much higher than traditional models as voters must select the right experts and decide whether their interests are better served by voting directly or by delegating, which could result in liquid democracy being much more dependent on its citizen's ability to correctly express their vote. This could also disengage people from politics as they could prefer to constantly delegate their votes and gradually lose interest in politics altogether, making the technical aspect of democracy chase away participation, as is often the case. Furthermore, problems of unequal voting power can also discourage ordinary members, as the flexible delegation component of this system means they compete against "super representatives" with thousands of votes, undermining direct participation. Lastly, I struggle to understand what triggers decision making in liquid democracy: what policies are subjected to vote? When is the voting phase stopped? In order to ensure meta delegation, a period long enough to allow multiple vote transfers is necessary, but instant recall makes it that the results are never the same at different points in time.

In order to tackle these problems, a set of modifications to liquid democracy are suggested by the authors. The first amelioration they propose is a deliberative phase between the delegation and final voting phases to incentivize participation of ordinary members. Allowing them to bring forward decisive argument that might convince influential representatives could balance the inequality of voting powers and increase the likeliness of reaching a better conclusion, strengthening the egalitarian justification of this model [citation]. Furthermore, limiting the role of liquid democracy to legislative decision making by allowing an elected executive to ensure consistency across policy

areas can solve the inconsistency problem. Besides, a reputation system binding experts to their previous votes can allow relatively uninformed voters to make competent choices through heuristic means. As it is easier to access someone's ability to have good judgement on a specific issue than it is to determine if they can be generally trusted with a wide array of policy areas, a track record of votes in the same topic is an excellent way to easily provide voters with quality information.

Lastly, I will address the feasibility of implementing such a system in existing democracies. Liquid democracy can seem like a utopian proposal for several reasons. Much of that has to do with unpredictable behavior from a variety of actors holding different positions and interests in present societies. Political parties for example, as this model suggests the abolition of the professional political class, would have to undergo significant changes. One can easily imagine them promoting experts and running campaigns for them, or even incentivizing people to give them their votes through democratically debatable means. Various decisions regarding the process of implementation can also largely affect the democratic results: assuming the vote count is done online, will anyone be able to access data such as how many votes each representative holds? This could not only influence the behavior of representatives but also the likeliness of an expert to gain or lose popularity as well as voting strategies and political corruption.

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